

MODDABLE CHESS · VARIANT 154 OF 155

Xiang Fu

9×9

BOARD

2

PLAYERS

XIANG FU

Xiang Fu () is a Xiangqi/chess hybrid created by Eventlesstew for the PyChess Variant Design Contest. It combines Xiangqi's ranging pieces with a dual-Champion checkmate system inspired by Spartan Chess. Piece drops and the Crossbow (a diagonal Cannon) add further tactical depth.

THE BOARD

A 9×9 grid. Each side's two **Champions** are confined to a **Ring** — a designated zone in each player's territory — and cannot leave it.

STARTING POSITION

Pieces occupy only the outer quadrants of the board at the start, with the centre empty.

Black (top-left quadrant, ranks 1–3):

- Rank 1: Chariot© · Bishop(d) · Mahout(e)
- Rank 2: Cannon© · Crossbow(d) · Horse(e)
- Rank 3: Champion© · · Champion(e)

Red (bottom-right quadrant, ranks 7–9):

- Rank 7: Champion(e) · · Champion(g)
- Rank 8: Horse(e) · Crossbow(f) · Cannon(g)
- Rank 9: Mahout(e) · Bishop(f) · Chariot(g)

FEN: 2rbm4/2cwn4/2+g1+g4/9/9/9/4+G1+G2/4NWC2/4MBR2 [] w - 0 1

(+G/+g = *Champion (royal)*, R/r = *Chariot*, B/b = *Bishop*, M/m = *Mahout*, C/c = *Cannon*, W/w = *Crossbow*, N/n = *Horse*.
Empty hand []. Red (w) moves first.)

WIN CONDITIONS (SPARTAN-STYLE)

Each side has **two Champions** (royal pieces):

- To win, either: **capture one of the opponent's Champions** (reducing them to a single Champion), then checkmate the remaining one in the standard way; OR
- Achieve **Duple Checkmate** — simultaneously attack both Champions so that neither can escape on the opponent's next move.

PIECE DROPS

Pieces you capture go to your hand. On any turn, instead of moving a piece on the board, you may **drop a captured piece** onto any empty square within your own **first two ranks**.

PIECES

PIECE	SYMBOL	MOVEMENT
Champion	+G	Moves one square any direction. Royal. Confined to the Ring.
Pupil	G	Moves one square any direction. Non-royal. (A captured Champion enters hand as a Pupil.)
Chariot	R	Slides any number of squares orthogonally (Xiangqi Chariot = Rook).
Horse	N	One step orthogonally then one step diagonally outward (Xiangqi Horse). Blockable.
Cannon	C	Slides orthogonally freely; to capture, must jump over exactly one screen piece.
Crossbow	W	Slides diagonally freely; to capture, must jump over exactly one screen piece on the diagonal. Diagonal version of the Cannon.
Mahout	M	Moves two squares in any direction (orthogonally or diagonally). Not a jump; blocked by intervening pieces.
Bishop	B	Slides any number of squares diagonally (chess Bishop). Not blockable by intervening pieces for diagonal slides.

RULES

- ♦ **Champions** are confined to the Ring at all times and cannot move outside it.
- ♦ **Drops** are limited to the dropping player's own first two ranks.
- ♦ When a Champion is captured, it enters the opponent's hand as a **Pupil** (non-royal) and may be dropped later.
- ♦ **Stalemate and repetition** work as in standard chess (draw), not Xiangqi rules.
- ♦ The Flying General rule (Generals cannot face each other on an open file) does **not** apply.

ATTRIBUTION

Xiang Fu was designed by Eventlesstew for the PyChess Variant Design Contest. Board corrected to 9×9 (not 9×10 as originally described). Rules documented from pychess.org/variants/xiangfu.